Selective Laser Trabeculoplasty (SLT)

AGS Patient Education Subcommittee of the Patient Care Committee

What is selective laser trabeculoplasty (SLT)?

SLT is a laser procedure done in the office to lower your eye pressure.

- Having high eye pressure can damage your optic nerve and cause permanent vision loss called glaucoma.
- Your eye pressure can be high because the drain in your eye is too slow.
- The drain of your eye is in the front part of the eye where your iris (the colored part of your eye) and cornea (the clear covering of the eye) meet.
- SLT makes the drain work better, which can lower your eye pressure.
- There is no way to reverse optic nerve damage or bring back vision that has already been lost. But, lowering your eye pressure can help slow the damage from glaucoma.



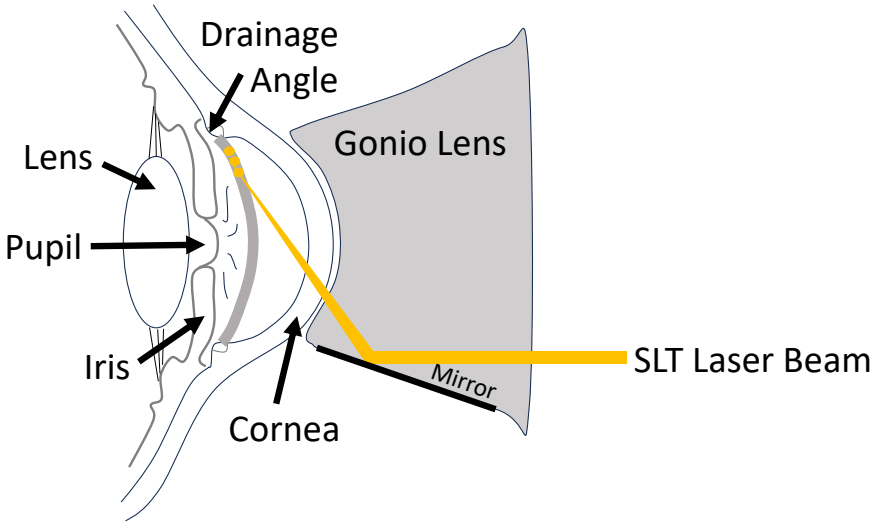
Image of patient getting laser treatment

How is the procedure performed?

The laser is done in the office and takes a few minutes.

- You will sit at the laser machine, and your eye will be numbed with eye drops.
- A lens will be placed on your eye, and your doctor will use a laser light to aim at the drain of your eye.
- You may feel some mild stinging or pressure during the laser, but most patients are very comfortable.
- There are no injections or needles involved.

American Glaucoma Society



What should I expect after the procedure?

After the laser, your vision may be blurry for a few hours.

- Plan to have someone drive you home after the laser, especially if both of your eyes are to be treated.
- You can resume your normal activities.
- You will get your eye pressure checked before you leave the office. If it is too high, your doctor may give you some drops in the office.
- Your doctor may prescribe some anti-inflammatory eye drops to be used for a few days after the laser.
- The laser does not lower your eye pressure right away. It can take up to a few weeks to see a lower eye pressure.
- This type of laser can be done again in the future.

What are the risks of the procedure?

SLT is a safe procedure. But with any procedure, there are risks:

- Sometimes your eye pressure may go up after the laser. This is usually for a short time but sometimes lasts longer. Sometimes, you may need more glaucoma drops or even surgery.
- Sometimes you may get some eye inflammation. Your doctor may give you drops to control the inflammation for a few days or weeks.

Summary

SLT is a type of laser used to treat glaucoma. It helps to lower your eye pressure by improving drainage from your eye. The procedure is safe and can be done more than once if needed.

655 Beach Street, San Francisco, CA 94109 415.561.8587 ags@aao.org

American Glaucoma Society